

SK1227 INSTITUTIONAL DEVELOPMENT AND DEMOCRATIZATION IN INTERNATIONAL PERSPECTIVE



UNIVERSITY OF
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Course Guide

Hi, y'all!

Here is how this course works (Spring 2026):

The course works in three cycles followed by concluding week and final exam.
Here is the first cycle:

Week 1

Me: I lecture one day and the day after.

You: Next, we get together - you discuss readings you have completed before the class has met. You work in groups, we break for class discussion of what the group thinks about the readings.

The pattern repeats one time, over the next week. Then we are done with weeks 1 and 2.

At the start of week 3, you submit your written assignment for this cycle.

Week 3:

We have a week in which we have presentations. You present *once* during the entire course. Your turn to present is determined randomly, in week 3, 6 or 9. You present on the written assignment you just turned in. In this week of presentations, regardless of whether it is your turn to present, you come to class one day. You will get, on Canvas, a personalized schedule telling you for which presentation session to come. That schedule will also contain information for how Discussions will run.

Then we are done with the first cycle.

This cycle repeats two more times, completing three total cycles.

We get to week 10. We sum up what we have learned.

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Lectures, Readings, Presentations:

- Cycle 1 Week 1to3 Autocracy:
- Introduction: The problem of governance. The State. Wealth, taxes, information. Selecting and replacing rulers. Standard of Ur/short [documentary](#) by Khan Academy. [Bolshevik Revolution](#). Transitions and Definitions. On war and how they end? Protests? Coups?

- Readings for lecture:
 1. Charles Tilly, “War making and state making as organized crime” in *Bringing the State Back In*, editors Dietrich Rueschmeyer, Peter Evans and Theda Skocpol, Cambridge University Press, 1985.
 2. Timothy Snyder, *Bloodlands: Europe Between Hitler and Stalin*, pages 1-89
 3. Milan Svolik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*, Cambridge University Press, 2012. Chapter 2 and Chapter 3
- Discussion first session:
 1. Scharpf, A. and Gläsel, C. (2020), Why Underachievers Dominate Secret Police Organizations: Evidence from Autocratic Argentina. *American Journal of Political Science*, 64: 791-806. [link](#)
 2. Espen Geelmuyden Rød, Nils B. Weidmann, “From bad to worse? How protest can foster armed conflict in autocracies,” *Political Geography*, 2023, [link](#)
- Discussion second session:
 1. Jennifer Gandhi, Ben Noble, Milan Svolik, “Legislatures and Legislative Politics without Democracy” in *Comparative Political Studies*, 2020. 53: 1359-1379. [link](#)
 2. 3rd EEAS Report on Foreign Information Manipulation and Interference Threats Exposing the architecture of FIMI operations [link](#)
- Policy Brief Questions (choose one):
 1. Under what conditions should the West encourage protest in autocracies?
 2. Under what conditions should the international community extend cooperation and recognition to dictatorships with institutions such as an elected legislature and more than one political party?
 3. How should the EU and its member states respond to authoritarian disinformation campaigns?
- Cycle 2 Week 4to6 Democracy:
- Introduction: What is? Where and how did it emerge? Does it correlate with power? Does it protect HR? Governance? Protests? Conspiracy/Identity Politics/Power passage/Corruption/Oligarchic Control/World Systems/Sovereignty/Wealth
- Readings for lecture:
 1. *Democracy and Development* by Przeworski et al., pp. 1-59
 2. *Sacred Foundations: The Religious and Medieval Roots of the European State* by Anna Grzymała-Busse, Introduction and Chapters 2 and 3 and 4. Available as online book from library, [link](#).
 3. Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy: Carl Schmitt - Read Section 2 Sovereignty and Dictatorship and Section 3 The Concept of the Political and the Critique of Liberalism [link](#)
- Discussion first session:
 1. Milan Svolik, “Polarization versus Democracy,” *Journal of Democracy* 30, No. 3 (July 2019), pp. 20-32 [link](#)
 2. Warnings From Weimar Why Bargaining With Authoritarians Fails Daniel Ziblatt [link](#)
- Discussion second session:

1. Umberto Eco, Ur-Fascism [link](#)
 2. Democratic Backsliding and De-Democratization: How the Georgian Dream Party Eroded the Rule of Law, Undermined the Integrity of Independent State Institutions, and Consolidated Power by Philipp H. Fluri and Tamar Pataraia, [link](#)
- Policy Brief Question:
 1. Pick a country of your choice that in your view has been sliding into authoritarianism. Briefly describe the ways in which it has slid into authoritarianism. Tell us for whether it is still a democracy or should be considered authoritarian, defend your classification. Tell us shortly what is the best hope for this country to maintain or restore its democracy. Specifically, who should do what to that end, and what are the odds for success? Note that you may want to do a bit of extra research on your own to get some background information if this is not a country we have already covered or you know much about.
 - Cycle 3 Week 7 to 9 The Democracy-Autocracy Nexus
 - Introduction: What do Dems want? What do auth want? Intl assistance, dem promotion, election-observation, coups, Russian propaganda, Intervention in Elections, sanctions, smart sanctions
 - Readings for lecture:
 1. Hal Brands, “American Grand Strategy and the Liberal Order”, RAND [link](#)
 2. The World Has Become Flatter for Authoritarian Regimes By Christopher Walker Journal of Democracy [link](#)
 3. Vachudova, The Leverage of International Institutions, EUI working paper, [link](#)
 4. Winzen, EU backsliding [link](#)
 - Discussion first session:
 1. The Stanford Review, Uncovering Chinese Academic Espionage at Stanford, Garret Molloy and Elsa Johnson [link](#)
 2. How Serbian Students Created a Network [link](#)
 - Discussion second session:
 1. John Mearsheimer, Why the War in Ukraine is the West’s Fault, in *Foreign Affairs* [link](#) *and* Maria Popova, “Liberation, not Collapse” in *Eurozine*, [link](#)
 2. John O Brennan, “Europe’s ‘Kidnapped East? Bulgaria’s unbreakable yoke of corruption” (see Canvas) *and* two short articles in *Politico*: [Europe’s liberals demand EU freezes funds to Bulgaria over imprisoned mayor](#) and [Jailed mayor urges EU to halt Bulgaria’s slide toward authoritarianism](#).
 - Policy Brief Questions (choose one):
 1. The mayor of Varna, Bulgaria, spent five months in jail in 2025. Many hoped the EU would facilitate his release from jail. Is there any evidence the EU played a passive or active role in his release? What does this tell us about the ability of the EU to have an effect on subnational democracy?

2. Moldova and Georgia seem to be on different paths. Some would argue that Moldova's more pro-Western trajectory is due to a more engaged EU strategy in the country. Do you agree or disagree? Answer the question broadly while describing the different ways in which pro-democratic and proauthoritarian forces have been intervening in the two countries, and tell us what you conclude about the ability of outsiders to affect democracy.
 3. Some would argue that giving Greenland to America will help the EU achieve stability in a changing geo-political order. Some say the opposite. Should the EU stand firm or hand over Greenland? Answer the question while defending your view in terms of Europe's core interests and the likely alignment of world forces in the near future.
- Week10: Amartya Sen, Human Rights, Syria, Why Nations Fail by Acemoglu and Robinson
 - These are readings you can read for additional insight
 1. Raymond Fisman and Edward Miguel, *Economic Gangsters: Corruption, Violence and the Poverty of Nations*, Princeton University Press, 2008. selections
 2. Sen Development as Freedom
 3. Svoboda, Milan W. 2023. Voting Against Autocracy. *World Politics* 75(4): 647–691. [link](#)
 4. “Ukraine’s Stolen Children: Inside Russia’s Network of Re-education and Militarization”, Yale School of Public Health, September 16, 2025. [link](#).
 5. Daron Acemoglu and James Robinson, *Why Nations Fail: The Origins of Power, Prosperity, and Poverty*, 2013. selections
 6. Zavadskaya Russian Emigrants [link](#)
 7. Dudko [Teaching E Europe](#)
 8. Russian Disinfo [link](#) by Roman Hlatsky
 9. Rulers on the Road [link](#)
 10. Dukalskis, Alexander. 2021. *Making the World Safe for Dictatorship*, OUP Chapter 4 “Selling Dictatorship and Silencing Dissent” [link](#)
 11. Nicolás Idrobo, “Why Economic Sanctions Backfire” [link](#)
 12. Jon Elster, “Accountability in Athenian Politics” in *Democracy, Accountability, and Representation*, editors Adam Przeworski, Susan C. Stokes, Bernard Manin, Cambridge University Press, 2012.
 13. Katherine Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*, pp. 1-25.
 14. Protests When Do Non-Violent Protests Succeed? [link](#)
 15. How to flip the Script of Auth Regimes [link](#)
 16. General Resource on Democracy [link](#)
 17. piece on Moldova, piece on Bulgaria x2, piece on how ideas of far-right spread
 18. “Defending Europe without the US: first estimates of what is needed” by Alexandr Burilkov and Guntram Wolff, Bruegel and Kiel Institute, [link](#) or “Can Europe Back Ukraine’s Fight Alone?” by Weiss and Rushton in *New Lines Magazine*, March 3, 2025 [link](#) and There’s Only One Way to Deal with Russia by Andrew Michta [link](#)
 19. ICE not only looks and acts like a paramilitary force – it is one, and that makes it harder to curb, by Erica De Bruin [link](#)
 20. When AI enters national elections - a piece by David Altman in J of Democracy [link](#)
 21. Van Coufudakis, the EEC and the Freezing of the Greek Association Agreement JCMS 1977 [link](#)

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Course Pages:

█ in Canvas

Office Hours:

█ After class, or by appointment, or post your questions in the forum provided for this purpose on Canvas

Objectives:

█ This course is primarily designed for undergraduate students. It is a general introduction to regimes and how the link between regimes and the international system

Prerequisites:

█ See Program Description

Course Meeting Times:

█ See Timeedit

Credits:

█ Each Cycle (1 2 3), which includes showing up for discussion, presentations, and turning in the assignment, gives you 3 credits. The presentation you deliver gives you 1 credit. The final exam is worth 5 credits.

Attendance:

█ Attending lectures is encouraged but not required. Discussion sessions should be attended. Attending one presentation in each presentation cycle is compulsory. See your assigned day for each such week.

Grading Policy:

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All assignments will be graded on a scale from Fail, to Pass, and to High Pass. This grading system will be official grade in Canvas, where will show up as U, G, or VG. For a pass grade (G), the student's work must demonstrate an ability to link theoretical analyses to empirical outcomes, an independent analytical ability and ability to produce structured academic writing. For a very good grade (VG), the student's work must show a very good ability to link theoretical analyses to empirical outcomes, good analytical ability and good academic writing. To pass with (G) the entire course, at least G is required in both written and oral parts and attendance at all compulsory parts. To obtain a grade of VG for the entire course, VG is required for at least half of the grades course outputs. To pass the course, you must pass all assignments. Late submissions cannot receive a High Pass. Students are expected to read the course literature, to prepare rigorously for seminars, and participate actively during seminars. If a student who has failed twice on the same examination component wishes to change examiner for the next examination session, such a request shall be submitted in writing to the department responsible for the course and shall be granted unless there are special reasons to the contrary. Students shall be offered at least five opportunities to take examinations in order to pass a course or part of a course. In the event that a course has been discontinued or undergone major changes, the student shall normally be guaranteed access to at least three examination opportunities (including regular examinations) over a period of at least one year, based on the previous structure of the course. This may not be contrary to (HF Chapter 6 §21).

Policy Briefs:

1. You pick one of the suggested questions
2. You answer it while thinking about and drawing on *all* the readings, slides, arguments we have developed. That means lecture, discussion, everything. To draw on all the readings does not mean you have to cite them *all* explicitly - but you need to consider whether or not someone's argument or way of thinking applies or supports your argument - and if it is relevant, use it.
3. You do not need a bibliography - simply reference the title or the name, I know which one it is.

Word limit: 850 words

4 Grading:

You will see:

A(argument) -.+

S(structure) -.+

R(readings) -.+

Plus means something is done really well. Minus means sth is lacking seriously.

Dot means okay.

Three pluses = VG. Pass with Distinction

Three minuses = UG. Fail

All other combinations: G Pass

Argument:

The argument needs to be clear and easily understandable to get a plus. If I can piece it together but need to work, that's a dot. If no argument appears present that's a minus.

Structure:

A plus means we have Intro and Conclusion paragraphs that clearly state your argument. Clear means also containing as much information as possible. So for example, it is better to say "I will argue that protest should be encouraged in consolidated dictatorships" than "I will argue that whether protest is encouraged should depend on the kind of dictatorship" and definitely better than only stating that "In what follows I will argue when protest should be encouraged". Note that the latter tells us nothing other than what we know, namely, you are simply stating that you will adhere to the topic of the essay something we take for granted. The essay should further have a few self-contained paragraphs of about 3-5 sentences each which make one specific argument or points that clearly belong together. A dot means that the argument is not stated clearly nonetheless the exposition flows in a manner that allows me to follow. A minus means paragraphs are super long, points appear jumbled together and the essay is nearly impossible to follow.

Also on structure - do not include section headings - "Intro", "Main", "Conclusion". Short essays do not benefit from such. The position and content of the paragraphs are enough to establish what they are about. Leave a blank line between paragraphs it helps when reading.

Do not cite or draw much on readings in the Intro. Just state clearly your argument. Do not clarify assumptions or offer definitions there - this is for main body. The Intro is for stating your argument.

Readings:

A plus means that you are drawing on a bunch of readings while focusing on the main points. You are able to say how your argument builds on each reading point that you bring up. ... cont.

Policy Briefs (cont'):

... A dot says that I see many of the readings referenced but their connection to your points is unclear. A minus indicates that you do not reference core readings or appear to misunderstand the authors' points. It is much better to organize paragraphs and the whole essay around the ideas and not the readings. The latter should play a strictly supporting role. So, for example, assume you are inspired to argue that protest should be encouraged in closed dictatorships and not in dictatorships with institutions. You start your paragraph with that - "Encouraging protest is better in dictatorships that do not allow any form of contestation", then continue "As Svolik tells us, such dictatorships are especially likely to block the public from participating (and ...)". This is preferable to you starting with - "let me tell you about how smart Svolik is, and his cool theory and then throw in sth about how I could use to argue for encouraging protests". When you start with Svolik, it feels you are simply summarizing. When you start with your argument, you are showing me that you can think, you can make arguments and you can use others to support and justify your ideas. These others, they are merely helping you. You are the one driving the train.

General writing things:

Being clear, using short sentences, drawing on examples, personal experiences always makes the story better.

Best not to write your name. I like reading blind as much as I can.

I can tell that some (small portion of) essays have been done exclusively with Chat GPT or similar. This results in subpar product and does not get you that many points. It will also be of no help on the final exam. It is much more fun to read, come to lecture, and make exciting arguments about the world - than enter the netherworld of AI.

Make-up:

If you missed a discussion session =

– > please write one page in which you discuss each of the usually two assigned readings. Tell me - 1 what is the main argument? 2 Do you agree or not? 3 What if anything should we do about the matter raised in the piece (adopt some policy, change how we do something, and so on)

If you missed a presentation, meaning you were due to be there when someone else presented but were not =

– > please plan to put in an additional appearance during some other presentation session. For example, if you did not come for any presentation under Cycle 2 so you missed your slot, you can simply come to two presentations under Cycle 3 - one, your assigned session, and one of the other two scheduled for Cycle 3 - your choice which one.

Exam:

There is a sit-down exam in which you answer questions related to the readings. There are 20 essay style questions calling for a one-paragraph long answer. You will receive examples of the questions in a Canvas module as soon as class opens. The questions will be similar to but not the same as those on the exam.

Presentations:

■ The presentations are graded as Pass or Fail. Fail is failing to address the topic. All else - pass.

Plagiarism:

■ Copying material from the Internet, from books, journals, reports, or from a fellow student and then presenting it as one's own is strictly forbidden! Plagiarism is theft of someone else's work and will result in immediate fail of the assignment. Please note that the inclusion of a source in a bibliography list is not in itself sufficient attribution of another's work. In addition, unless it is a proper citation with a reference, any direct copying of text is forbidden. All submitted student work is screened with a program, which compares a student's written work with published materials (including everything published on the internet) and all the work from prior students, to detect plagiarism. The material you have read and based your arguments and factual statements on should always be referenced using proper referencing technique. More information on references and how to avoid plagiarism can be found here: [Student Portal](#)

All your submitted texts should be your own original writing, and not written by someone else or generated by AI. Unless there are specific instructions for the use of AI for an assignment, it should not be used and presented as your own text. The use of any tools to cheat during on campus exams (e.g. DISA) is also strictly forbidden. Students can discuss their work among each other, but individual submissions must be your own original writing, and hence not too similar the work of others. Be extra careful to avoid using common notes from such collaborations.

Any kind of cheating on examinations is considered a serious offense. Proved or suspected cheating will be reported to the Disciplinary Committee of the University of Gothenburg, in accordance with the procedure of disciplinary matters at the department of political science. A student may be suspended from classes and campus for a determined time-period (from 3 weeks to half a year), which will result in a temporary suspension of all financial aid (including CSN) and may jeopardize a student's residence permit status. More information on disciplinary matters, including plagiarism and its consequences, can be found here: [student portal](#)

Equal treatment:

■ The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, equal treatment representative, or student counselor. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these persons if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if not targeted at you. All contact information is available on our website.

Important Dates:

■ Sign up for Canvas updates. In Canvas, each Cycle appears as a Module.